Week 5: Group Activity Worksheet

Crop Comics — New Stories from Random Images

Tutorial Objective: Find out how much **cropping** alone can change what an image means. Using only the crop technique in Photoshop or Photopea, turn a set of random, unrelated images into a new comic story.

Links to Subject Outcomes: Apply image, text and layout composition (cropping, framing, visual grouping); apply visual elements and principles in narration; apply semiotics (context changes meaning).

How This Tutorial Runs

Activity	Mode
Briefing: crop as storytelling, shot sizes, rules	Whole class
Part A – Collect random images	Individual
Part B – Crop experiments	Individual (Photopea)
Part C – Write the storyline and panel plan	Individual
Part D – Produce the comic in Photoshop / Photopea	Individual
Part E – Gallery walk and peer feedback	Groups
Part F – Blackboard upload	Individual

Materials and Software

☐ Laptop / computer lab PC with internet
☐ **Photopea** (free, in the browser: photopea.com) **or** Adobe Photoshop
☐ A folder named `W05_images` to store your downloads
☐ This worksheet and your Visual Journal

Student Information

Field	Details
English Full Name	
Student ID	
Tutorial Class	
Date	
Software Used	☐ Photopea ☐ Photoshop

The Crop-Only Rule

✅ Allowed	❌ Not Allowed
Crop tool (C)	Brush, pencil, eraser painting
Moving and placing images	Clone stamp, healing, content-aware fill
Proportional scaling (hold Shift / keep ratio)	Generative fill / any AI image generation
Rotating whole images	Filters, colour or tone adjustments
Rectangular panel frames and gutters	Distorting, warping, stretching
Clipping an image into a rectangular panel	Drawing or adding objects
Optional caption bar **under** a panel (max 10 words)	Speech bubbles or text placed on the image

The challenge: the story must come from WHAT you show and WHAT you hide, not from editing the pixels.

Part A: Collect Random Images

A.1 Randomness Method

Choose **one** method so your images are truly random and unrelated.

☐ **Random word method:** use a random word generator, search each word on a free image site, and take the **first** usable result.
☐ **Random page method:** open a free image site's "random" or "new" feed and take every 3rd image.
☐ **Dice method:** roll a die for the category (1 people · 2 animals · 3 objects · 4 places · 5 nature · 6 food).

Free-licence sources: Unsplash · Pexels · Pixabay · Wikimedia Commons

Target: collect **10–15 images**. Do not plan the story yet!

A.2 Image Source Log

#	Short Description	Source Site	Photographer / Author	Link	Licence
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					

A.2 Image Source Log *(continued)*

#	Short Description	Source Site	Photographer / Author	Link	Licence
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Random method used and words / numbers generated:

Part B: Crop Experiments

B.1 Shot Size Vocabulary

Shot Size	What It Shows	Effect on the Viewer
Extreme wide	Whole environment, subject tiny	Isolation, scale, setting the scene
Wide	Full subject plus surroundings	Context, action
Medium	Subject from the waist up / main part	Neutral, conversation
Close-up	Face or key object	Emotion, importance
Extreme close-up	A small detail (eye, hand, texture)	Tension, mystery, focus

Crop Strategies

Conceal (hide context to create mystery) · **Reveal** (show context later for a twist) · **Re-cast** (make a background detail the new main character) · **Re-frame** (move the subject off-centre to create tension or movement)

B.2 One Image, Four Meanings

Choose **3 images**. Crop each one in **4 different ways** and record how the meaning changes.

Image #	Crop 1 (wide)	Crop 2 (medium)	Crop 3 (close-up)	Crop 4 (detail)
___	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:
___	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:
___	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:	Meaning:

Which crop changed the meaning the most? Why?

Part C: Storyline and Panel Plan

C.1 Find the Story

Spread your crops out (Photopea: open them all as tabs). Look for **characters**, **places** and **objects** that could connect.

Story Title:

Logline (one sentence):

Element	From Image #	Crop Used
Main character		
Setting		
Key object / problem		
Twist / ending		

C.2 Storyline

Story Stage	What Happens	Emotion
Set-up		
Problem		
Rising action		
Climax		
Ending / twist		

Full storyline (80–150 words):

C.3 Panel Plan (6–8 panels)

Panel	Image #	Shot Size	Crop Strategy	What the Audience Sees	Story Beat	Caption *(optional, ≤10 words)*
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						

C.4 Page Layout Thumbnail

Sketch your comic page layout. Use a **grid** (link to Weeks 3–4). Vary panel sizes to create rhythm and emphasis: make the climax panel the largest.

Part D: Production in Photopea / Photoshop

D.1 Set Up the Canvas

Step	Action	☐
1	**File** → **New**. Choose A4 portrait (2480 × 3508 px, 300 ppi) or Instagram 1080 × 1350 px.	☐
2	**View** → **Show** → **Grid / Guides**. Add guides for margins (e.g. 120 px) and gutters (e.g. 40 px).	☐
3	Use the **Rectangle tool** (no stroke, any fill) to draw each panel frame on its own layer. Name layers `P1`, `P2`, …	☐
4	Fill the background (white or black) on a separate layer.	☐

D.2 Place and Crop Each Panel

Step	Action	☐
5	**File** → **Open & Place** (Photopea) or **File** → **Place Embedded** (Photoshop) to bring in an image.	☐
6	Move the image layer **directly above** its panel layer.	☐
7	Right-click the image layer → **Create Clipping Mask**. The image is now cropped to the panel.	☐
8	**Ctrl/Cmd + T** → scale **proportionally** (Shift / chain-lock) and move to choose the crop.	☐
9	Alternatively, crop the image first with the **Crop tool (C)** in its own tab, then place it.	☐
10	Repeat for every panel. Check the reading order (left → right, top → bottom).	☐
11	Optional: add a caption bar **below** the panel with the Type tool (≤ 10 words).	☐

D.3 Export

Step	Action	☐
12	Save the editable file: **File** → **Save as PSD** → `W05_[Name]_comic.psd`	☐
13	Export the comic: **File** → **Export as** → **PNG or JPG** (quality 90%+)	☐
14	Export a **PDF** for Blackboard (Photopea: Export as → PDF)	☐
15	Take **2–3 screenshots of your layers panel** as proof of the crop-only process	☐

Crop-Only Self-Check

☐ No painting, cloning or AI fill ☐ No colour or filter changes ☐ All scaling is proportional ☐ Text only in caption bars (if any)

Part E: Gallery Walk and Peer Feedback

Leave your comic open on screen. Walk around and give feedback to **two** classmates. Ask two classmates to fill in your table.

Reviewer Name	Story I understood (1 sentence)	Best crop & why	Did they follow the crop-only rule?	One suggestion
			☐ Yes ☐ No	
			☐ Yes ☐ No	

Part F: Reflection

How did cropping change the original meaning of the images? Give one specific example.

What was the hardest part of making a story without drawing or editing?

How could the crop technique help you in future design work (posters, websites, social media)?

Blackboard Submission

Upload Checklist

☐ **Storyline** (C.1, C.2) and **panel plan** (C.3)
☐ **Final comic** (PNG / JPG at full resolution)
☐ Crop experiments (B.2)
☐ Image source log (A.2) with licences
☐ Layers panel screenshots (D.3) and peer feedback / reflection

File Requirements

Item	Requirement
Format	① Comic PNG/JPG ② One PDF with storyline + process + comic
File Names	`W05_[EnglishFullName]_[StudentNumber]_comic.png` and `W05_[EnglishFullName]_[StudentNumber].pdf`
Location	Blackboard → SSHD2382 → Week 5 → Crop Comic
Deadline	Before the start of the Week 6 tutorial

Additional Notes

References & Resources

Every image used must be credited here (author, site, link, licence), matching your source log: